

I think concerns about AI energy usage are way overblown

Posted by u/Dr_OttoOctavius • 0 points • 7 comments

Every time I bring up AI in conversations with friends and coworkers, I hear the exact same tired soundbite about how AI "uses too much energy" and is putting out too much CO2 in the atmosphere and is "ruining the planet." There are a lot of valid complaints about AI like it's propensity to hallucinate and make things up, the massive amount of AI generated slop polluting the internet, and bots pretending to be human spewing propaganda but I think the energy argument is bullcrap. I bet more energy is wasted making and distributing pornography, but you don't hear anyone complaining about that. Even if there was some kind of a valid argument, AI will only become more efficient as the programming gets better and computing hardware becomes more efficient.

Comments

u/BrushCommon4734 • 1 points • 2025-05-21 17:02 UTC

You have a very low understanding (or apparent interest in understanding) the math of energy consumption. Too fanboyed by AI to admit that it hogs electrons. It's not much different than saying global warming is a hoax by simply ignoring the evidence.

u/prince_0611 • 1 points • 2025-04-17 11:29 UTC

Isn't crypto very power intensive because it's a bunch of gpus running 24/7? Same case with AI which is a bunch of gpus running 24/7

u/ceetwothree • 2 points • 2025-04-17 03:44 UTC

Naw dude , it's actually pretty dramatic.

The more computation something does , the more power it consumes (there's nuance to that , but it's broadly true).

I worked tech as we moved from supercomputers and relational data models to massively parallelized commodity computers and things like map reduce and key value pair stores. This started around 2005ish ,

The old relational data way has sort of hard scaling limits , you could only go 4 wide or 8 wide until keeping them in sync cost you too much and you needed hardware bigger than you could buy , the newer map reduce way can scale horizontally essentially infinitely , but assembling a query cost way more power.

AI really only works because of massively parallel high power consumption parts running behind it. So when you hit chat GPT with a query it's functionally a thousand desktops spinning up in parallel to get your answer as fast as you get it.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-04-17 01:27 UTC

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u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-04-17 01:24 UTC

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u/No-Supermarket-4022 • 3 points • 2025-04-17 00:56 UTC

> AI will only become more efficient as the programming gets better and computing hardware becomes more efficient.

There's an adversarial element to AI and Crypto. If your AI and my AI are about as efficient as each other, I might just throw more power at my AI to out-think your AI.

Crypto and AI electricity consumed are WAY more than porn.

<https://www.iea.org/reports/energy-and-ai>

u/JoshuaCocks • 1 points • 2025-04-17 01:19 UTC

You forgot the man hours lost, to man cranking themselves instead of electric motors.

u/TimeSpiralNemesis • 1 points • 2025-04-17 00:41 UTC

The energy usage thing is the absolute lamest lie they use. Imagine if we added up all the energy and resources it took to make drawing pencils.

Honestly in a few years they'll move onto the next cool thing the internet tells them to hate and we can see constant spam about how genetic engineering slop is killing the planet because cat girls have no soul or something equally bizarre lol.